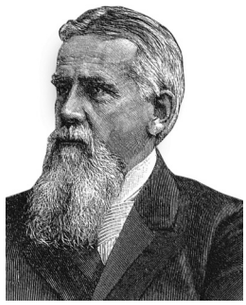
important in the discipline of geography due to the emphasis on location of phenomena on the earth surface, e.g. location of trade routes, relief features and settlements.

1.3.2 The period between 1800–1950

The period between 1800 and 1950 was characterised by the work of various individual philosophers who helped to expand the scope of geography. The discipline of geography became more distinct as a subject matter. Geographic knowledge saw strong growth in Europe and the United States in the 1800s. This period also saw the emergence of a number of societies interested in geographic issues. In Germany, Alexander Von Humboldt, Carl Ritter and Friedrich Ratzel made substantial contributions to human and physical geography. Humboldt's publication 'Kosmos' in 1844, examines the geology and physical geography of the earth. This work is still considered by many academics as a milestone contribution to geography.

There are two schools of thought that emerged during this period as an attempt to explain the relationship between human beings and their environment. These were *environmental determinism* and *possibilism*. Proponents of environmental deterministic school of thought such as Mackinder, Ellen Semple and Huntington believed that human actions and activities were moulded by the physical (natural) conditions. In several developing countries, human beings are susceptible to natural disasters such as drought, famine, floods and earthquakes. Human beings under such natural conditions usually surrender to nature. A good example of environmental determinism is the influence of the natural environment on human activities such as nomadic pastoralism. Nomadic pastoralism is so much dependent on the natural environment. Pastoralists do very little to modify their environment.



Ratzel



La Blache

The proponents of possibilistic school of thought, such as Vidal de la Blache saw the environment as a limiting factor rather than as a deterministic force. According to the possibilism school of thought, human beings have several alternatives in their environment and their actions are influenced by the decisions they make in the environment. For instance, humans can survive in hot or extremely cold conditions due to their ability to modify the environment to suit them. A good example is that in many arid countries such as Israel, humans have overcome the constraints set by the natural environment such as low rainfall, high temperatures and poor soils.

1.3.3 The period after 1950

Until 1950s, geography was more of an art subject where facts were established by casual observation in the field rather than by careful measurement and hypothesis testing. In the 1950s there was a new development in the discipline and several laws were established to explain geographical phenomena. Using the laws, it is possible to predict what will happen in the future. If we can predict

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